Chapter 2

Managing and Writing Emails with AI

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» **Choosing Copilot to help with email**

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In the bustling world of technology, the humble email holds its own as a gateway to an interconnected universe. Although the exact percentage varies (depending on the source), it's estimated that three-quarters of all communication is via email. And the percentage has probably increased since the COVID-19 pandemic. Some people say that email is passé and can be replaced by Google Chat, Teams, Slack, Hangouts Meet, or BlueJean Meetings; however, email isn't going away anytime soon.

Mastering the art of emails extends beyond crafting eloquent prose. Striking a balance between appropriateness and impact, and knowing which emails to prioritize or ignore are just as important. This chapter unlocks solutions to the challenges of composing compelling emails and managing emails you receive.

Using AI as Your Assistant for Writing Emails

AI has significantly transformed the landscape of communication, including how we send and receive emails. Here are some ways in which AI is reshaping email:

- **Cybersecurity:** Improving email security. AI can help identify and prevent email-based cyberattacks by detecting malicious content and attachments.
- **Personalization:** Writing personalized emails that are tailored to the recipient's interests and preferences. Personalization can increase the likelihood of open rates, click rates, and conversions.
- **Systematized responses:** Responding to incoming emails automatically, which can help businesses save time and resources.
- **Subject line optimization:** Analyzing the words, phrases, and subject lines that receive the most engagement and using that information to generate more effective subject lines that say "read me."
- **Tone analysis:** Analyzing a person's writing style and tone and suggesting changes to make the email more effective and engaging.
- **Scheduling:** Assessing when people are most likely to open and engage with emails and automatically scheduling emails to be sent at those optimal times.
- **Efficiency:** Streamlining email communication by prioritizing important messages and filtering out *spam* (unsolicited and unwanted messages sent in bulk to a large number of recipients). Increasing efficiency can save time and increase productivity.
- **Email copywriting:** Generating high-converting email campaigns in just a few clicks to analyze customer data and write personalized emails that resonate with the target audience.

Figure 2-1 is an example of AI to the rescue: Dan has an employee who's constantly missing team meetings. Dan spoke with the employee, but he needs to capture the conversation in writing in case this needs to escalate to the next level. Dan hopes this employee will change their behavior. He's laid out some strategies. The figure shows the input given to `You.com` and how the chatbot responded. Pay special attention to the strong subject line the chatbot created.

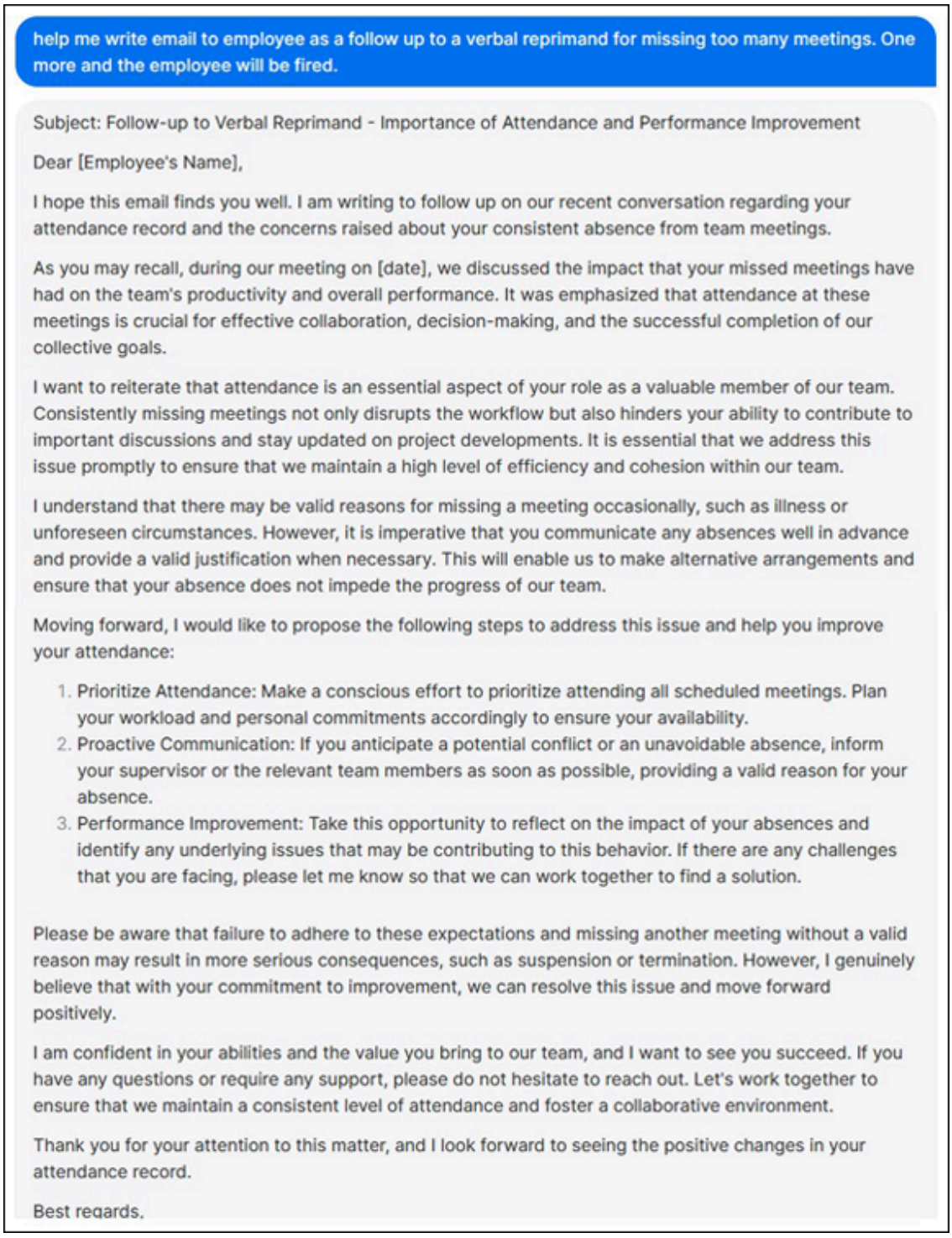


FIGURE 2-1: AI to the rescue.

Here are just a few of the many AI email assistants that can boost your email productivity:

- Capterra (`https://www.capterra.com/`)
- ChatGPT (`https://chat.openai.com/auth/login`)
- EmailTree (`https://emailtree.ai/`)
- Google Workspace (`https://workspace.google.com/`)
- Grammarly (`www.grammarly.com`)
- HubSpot (`https://www.hubspot.com/`)

- Mailbutler (`https://www.mailbutler.io/`)
- QuickMail (`https://quickmail.com/`)
- Sanebox (`https://www.sanebox.com/`)
- YAMM (`https://yamm.com/`)
- Microsoft 365 Copilot (`https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/copilot`)

Generating Precise Prompts

Here are some suggestions for creating effective AI prompts, with a particular emphasis on emails:

- Include the recipient's information and your relationship (client, business partner, colleague, for example) as this will influence the tone and formality.
- State the purpose of the message.
- Outline the main points or information you want to include.
- Incorporate the call to action.
- Request a descriptive subject line.



WARNING Although you should indicate your relationship to the person you're emailing in a prompt, never submit email addresses or personally identifying information (PII) to a generative AI (GenAI) model. Remember that some chatbots use information about prompts to train the model. This can potentially result in the GenAI model leaking the personal information to someone who shouldn't have it.

Emailing with Copilot

If you use Microsoft Outlook as your primary email program and you have a subscription to Copilot Pro or Microsoft 365 Copilot, you have access to an AI assistant that can help you process, understand, and respond to emails more efficiently and maybe even more effectively.



REMEMBER Book 2, Chapter 5 tells you how to sign up for and get started with Microsoft Copilot, Copilot Pro, or Microsoft 365 Copilot.

In the rest of this chapter, you learn how to use Copilot in Microsoft Outlook. Although the details differ between AI assistants in other email programs, most of the techniques and strategies you learn here are directly applicable to getting help with your email from other AI email assistants.

Summarizing with Copilot

Complex work or personal projects often result in long email threads, and it can sometimes be difficult to keep track of who said what or who agreed to what. One of the first features that you'll notice when you start using Copilot in Outlook is the Summary feature. Summary can take a single email, or a thread of emails, and distill them down to just the important information.

Summarizing email threads

For example, here's a (fake, mostly) conversation between members of a family who are making plans for their mother's 80th birthday.

```
From: Beth <beth@family.com>
Date: Saturday, August 10, 2024 at 7:58 AM
To: Chris, David, Kathy
Subject: Mom's b-day

What should we do for mom's birthday? I'm planning to come
to town with the kids. G might have to be in Dallas that
weekend, so I don't know if he'll be there.

From: Chris <chris@family.com>
Date: Saturday, August 10, 2024 at 8:18 AM
To: Beth, David, Kathy
```

Subject: Re: Mom's b-day

Cool! We'll be there, too. I'll start looking at flights!

---

beth@family.com wrote:

What should we do for mom's birthday? I'm planning to come to town with the kids. G might have to be in Dallas that weekend, so I don't know if he'll be there.

From: Kathy <kathy@family.com>
Date: Saturday, August 10, 2024 at 8:19 AM
To: Beth, David, Chris
Subject: Re: Re: Mom's b-day

Yay! Want to do something at the park? We could hire a band and get a clown, maybe? :) Chris, will you be able to make it, too?

From: Kathy <kathy@family.com>
Date: Saturday, August 10, 2024 at 8:19 AM
To: Beth, David, Chris
Subject: Re: Re: Mom's b-day

Oh, I just saw this. Ignore my last message. Great! You can stay with us!

---

chris@family.com wrote:

Cool! We'll be there, too. I'll start looking at flights!

I'll spare you all the rest of the details, but we've all been involved with email threads like this where the details of who is doing what and what's been agreed to — and even who's talking — start to get blurred.

Copilot's email thread summarization can help make sense of it all. To have Copilot generate a summary, select a message in the email thread and click the Summary by Copilot link, which will be right above the window that displays the email, as shown in Figure 2-2.

Clicking the Summary by Copilot link opens a window above the current email where Copilot generates a summary of the thread, complete with references to individual emails to back up each line of its summary, as shown in Figure 2-3.

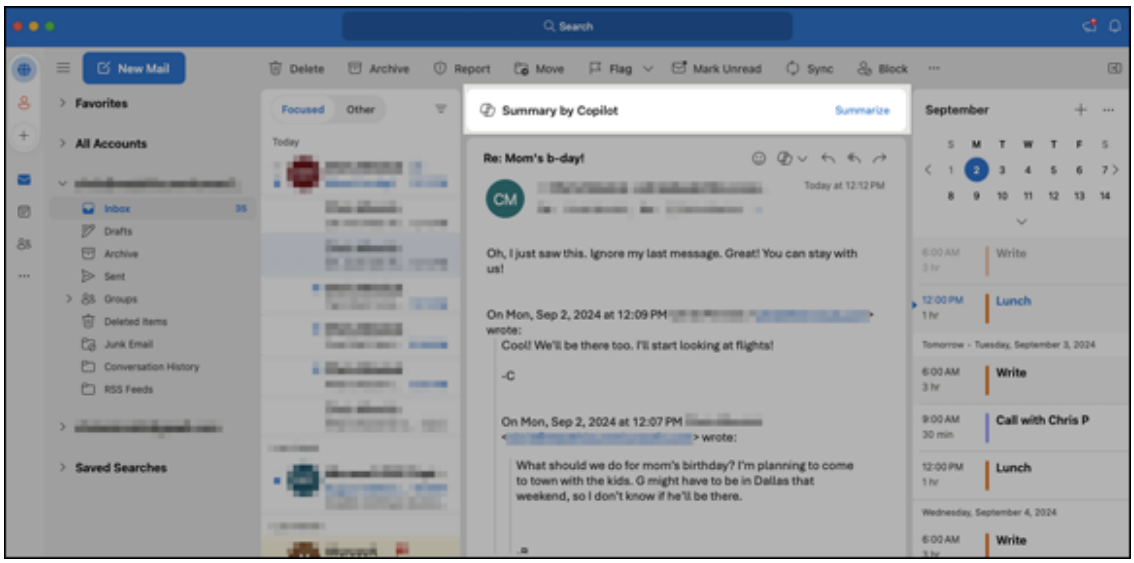


FIGURE 2-2: The Summary by Copilot link.

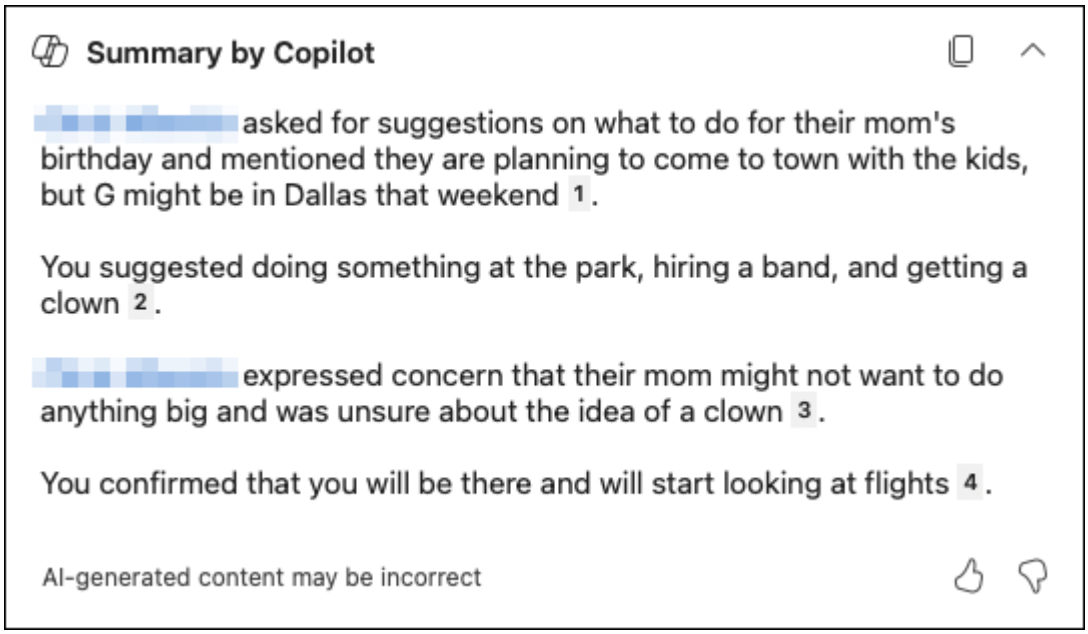


FIGURE 2-3: Copilot generates a summary of the thread.

Summarizing long emails

Copilot can also generate summaries of long emails. For example, meetings can often result in long emails that summarize the highlights of the meeting. Since you were at the meeting, such emails might seem redundant. Still, you might have agreed to do something (or someone thought you did, anyway) while you were distracted by the coffee and bagels. You shouldn't have to relive that meeting by having to read every word of the summary email.

Instead, you can ask Copilot to generate a short summary of the meeting that includes anything that mentions your name or something you might need to do to follow up.

Composing Emails with Copilot

Copilot can help write emails by either creating entire emails in response to your prompts or by analyzing text that you write and making suggestions for how you might improve it.

Drafting emails with Copilot

If you press the / key in a new email or at the beginning of a reply message, a menu will display showing files from your SharePoint or OneDrive cloud storage. At the top of that list is an option called Draft with Copilot. Selecting this option opens the Draft with Copilot window, which is shown in Figure 2-4.



FIGURE 2-4: The Draft with Copilot window.



REMEMBER The / character can always be used in Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat to open a menu for referencing other documents, people, meetings, or emails. It can also be used in certain other situations as well, such as to open the Draft with Copilot window in a Word document.

Inside the Draft with Copilot window, you can type a prompt that describes what you want the email to say. Before you ask Copilot to generate the email, you can select the tone and length of the email by clicking the Options menu link in the lower-left corner of the window. For example, in the message shown in Figure 2-5, I want to write a long and casual email thanking my significant other for making grilled cheese sandwiches.

The resulting email wasn't as long as I had hoped for, but it did accurately reflect the sentiment that I wanted to express. It doesn't sound like an email I'd write, but I thought Jill would still appreciate it (maybe not as much as if I'd actually written it, however). The generated email is shown in Figure 2-6.

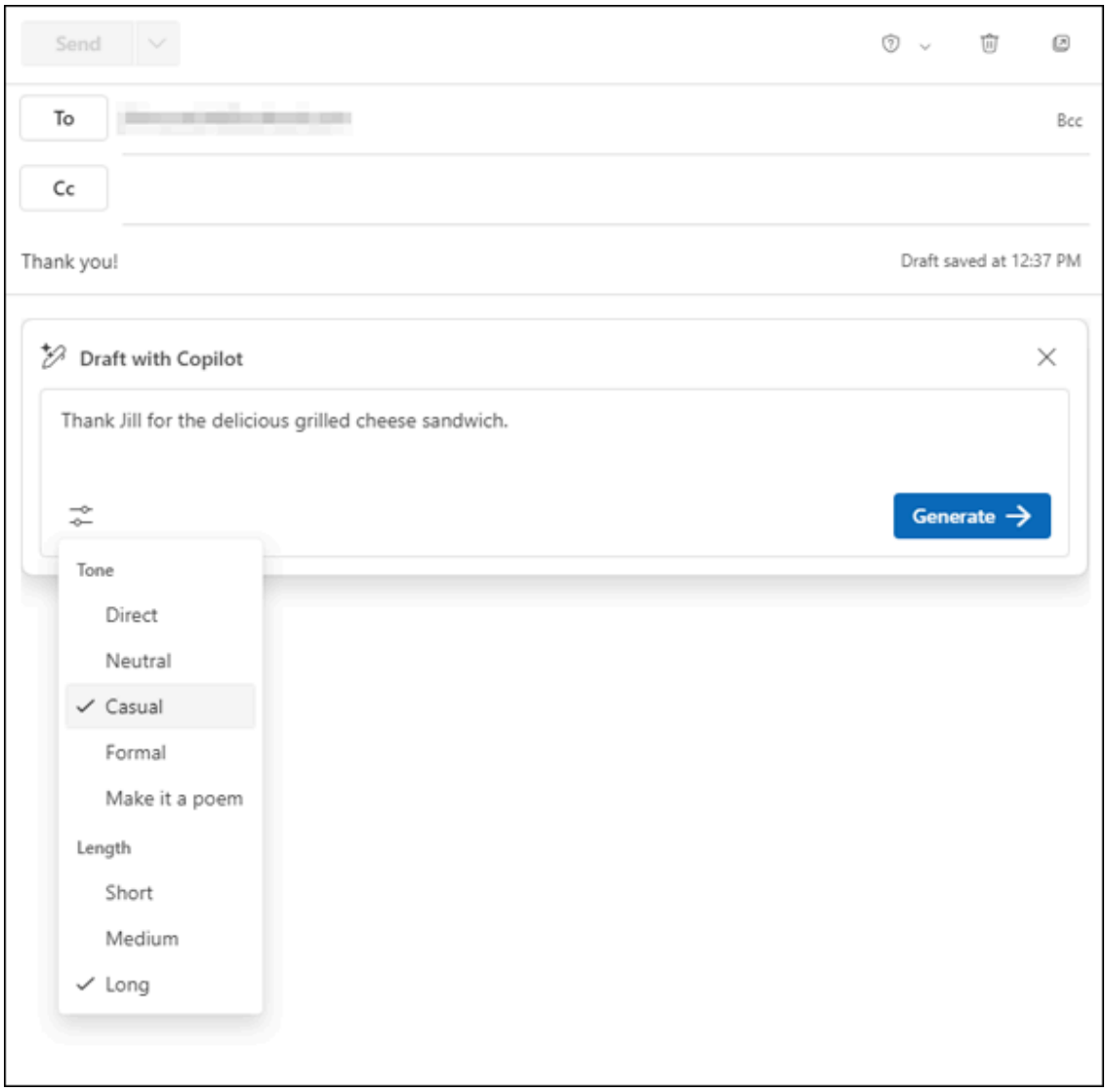


FIGURE 2-5: Prompting for an email.

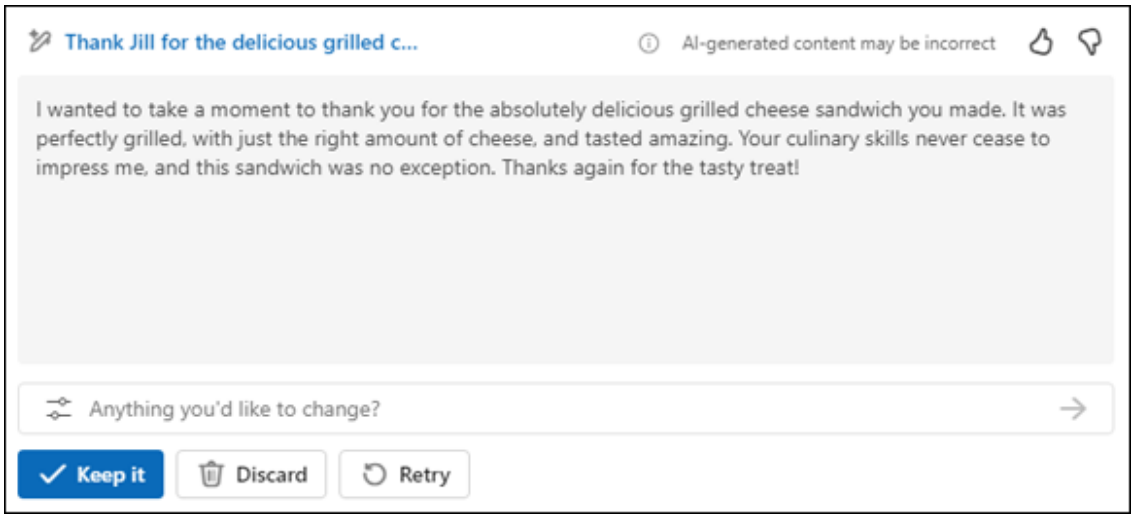


FIGURE 2-6: Copilot's generated email.

Just for fun, I thought I'd see if I could get Copilot to spice it up a bit. I submitted a follow-up prompt asking Copilot to try again and to use more slang and humor that a Gen-X person might use in such an email. After

seeing what it did (which was, as the young folks might say, cringe), I decided to stick with the original.

To go back in your history of prompts, click the back arrow in the upper-left corner of the Draft with Copilot window, which you can see in the new email draft shown in Figure 2-7.

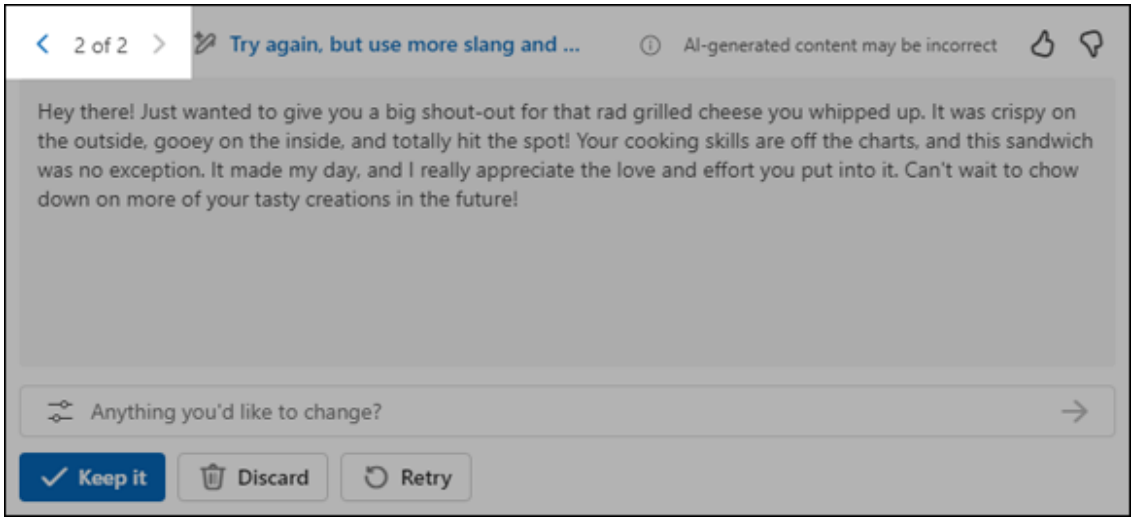


FIGURE 2-7: The new draft and the back arrow.

After Copilot generates an email, you can submit another follow-up prompt with any changes you'd like Copilot to make, or you can keep or discard the draft. I decided to use one of the preset follow-up prompts (which can be accessed using the menu on the left of the follow-up prompt area) to turn the email into a poem. The result is shown in Figure 2-8.

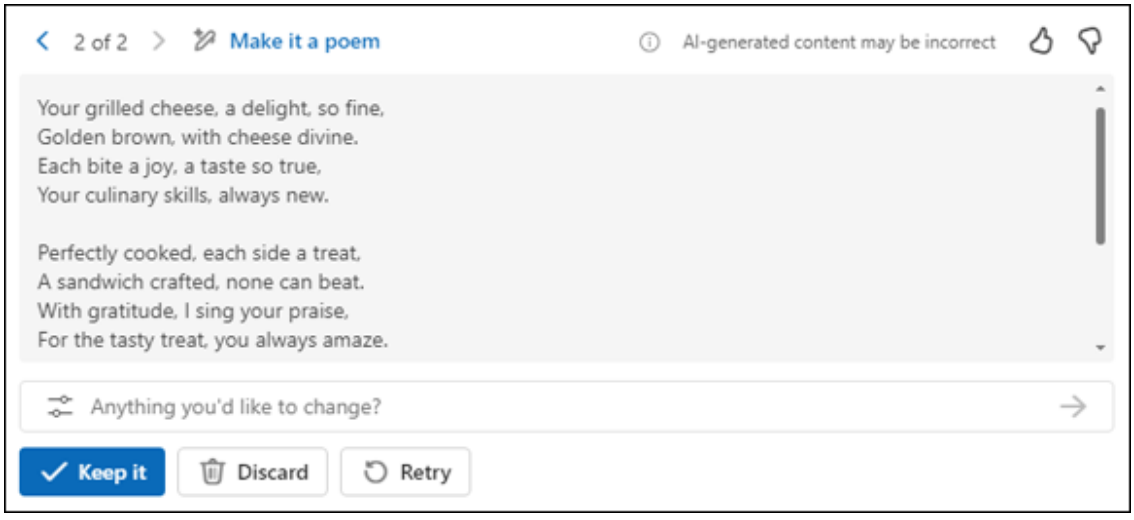


FIGURE 2-8: Copilot's thank-you poem.

In the end, I decided to just tell her thanks in person — and also to include these thank-you messages in my book, of course.

Reply suggestions

When you click the Reply button on an email, Copilot attempts to use the content of the message to suggest possible responses. These responses appear in a Draft with Copilot window at the bottom of your email, as shown in Figure 2-9.

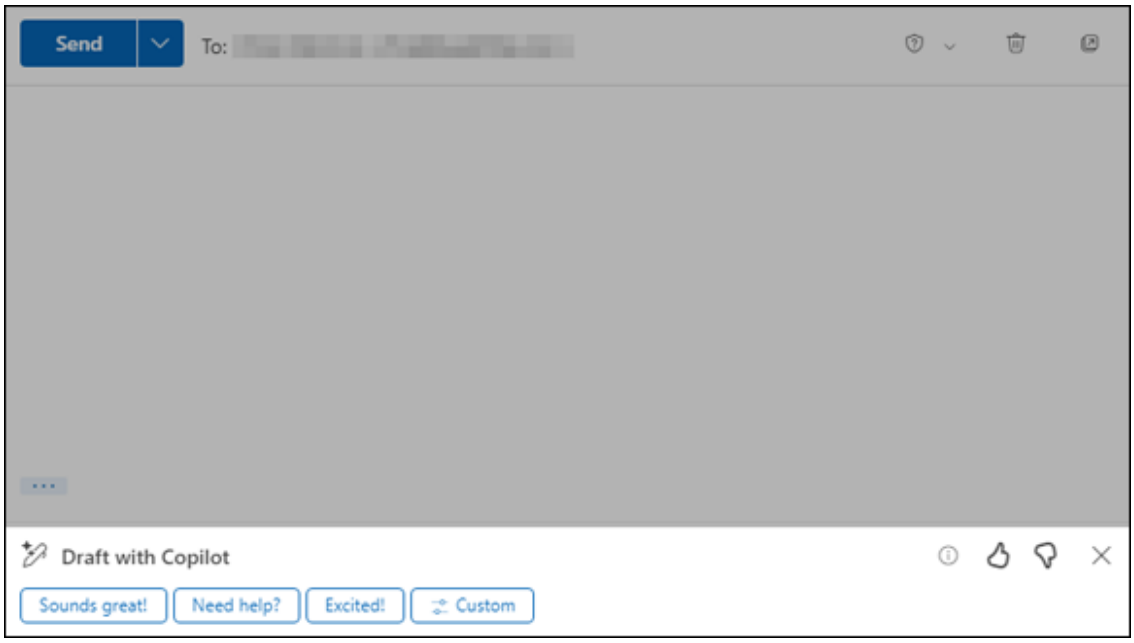


FIGURE 2-9: Copilot provides reply suggestions.

If you like one of Copilot's suggestions, you can click on it, and the text of the suggestion will appear in a Draft with Copilot window, where you can refine it or just add it to your message.

If you don't like any of the suggested responses but you still want to use Copilot to generate your response, you can click on the button labeled Custom to open the same Draft with Copilot window that appears when you use Copilot to draft a new email.

Email coaching

Copilot in Outlook offers a feature called Coaching by Copilot that gives you tips on how it thinks your email could be improved. To launch

Coaching by Copilot, select it from the Copilot menu as you're writing an email, as shown in Figure 2-10.

One necessary downside of Coaching by Copilot is that it only works with emails that contain at least 100 characters. If you try Coaching by Copilot with a shorter email, you'll get a message such as the one shown in Figure 2-11 telling you it can't help you.

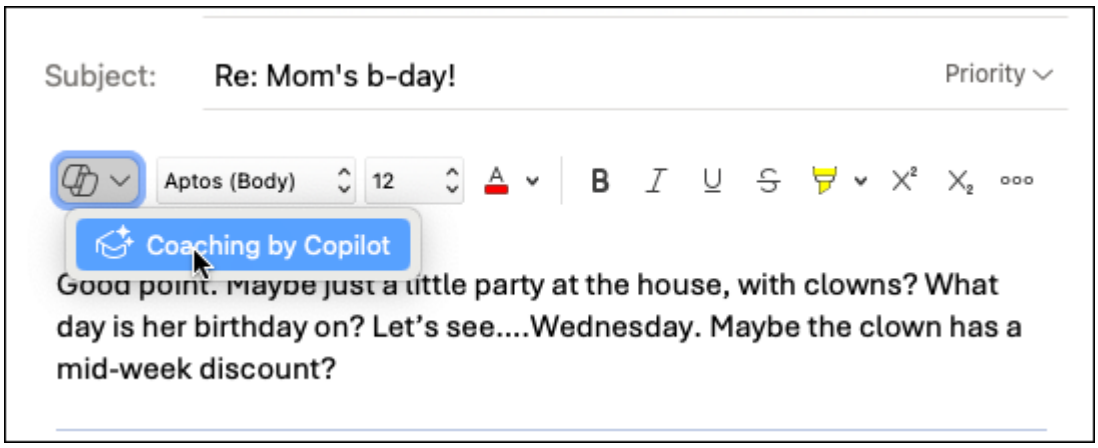


FIGURE 2-10: Starting Coaching by Copilot.

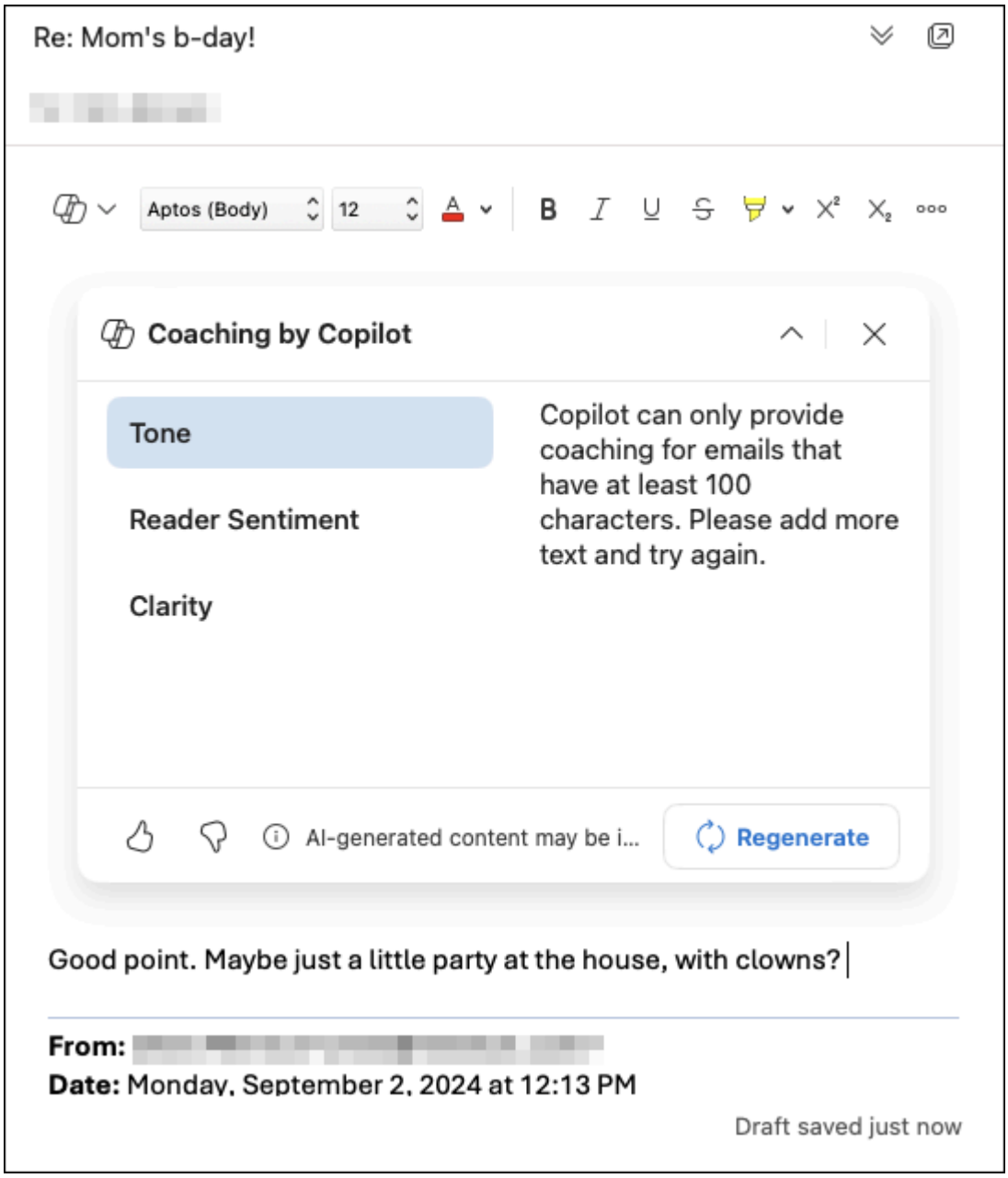


FIGURE 2-11: Coaching doesn't work on short emails.

Provided that you do have enough text in your draft email, Coaching by Copilot will show you suggestions for how to improve three aspects of your draft:

- **Tone:** Copilot gives suggestions for making your email sound friendlier.
- **Reader sentiment:** These suggestions are aimed at making the reader feel "included." Examples of suggestions that might fall into this category are suggestions such as ending your email with "What do you think?"
- **Clarity:** The Clarity category of suggestions are ways that Copilot thinks you might specify the details of your email more clearly.

In my experience with Coaching by Copilot, it often provided good suggestions, but it interpreted jokes literally and ruined them.

Figure 2-12 shows a typical suggestion from Coaching by Copilot.

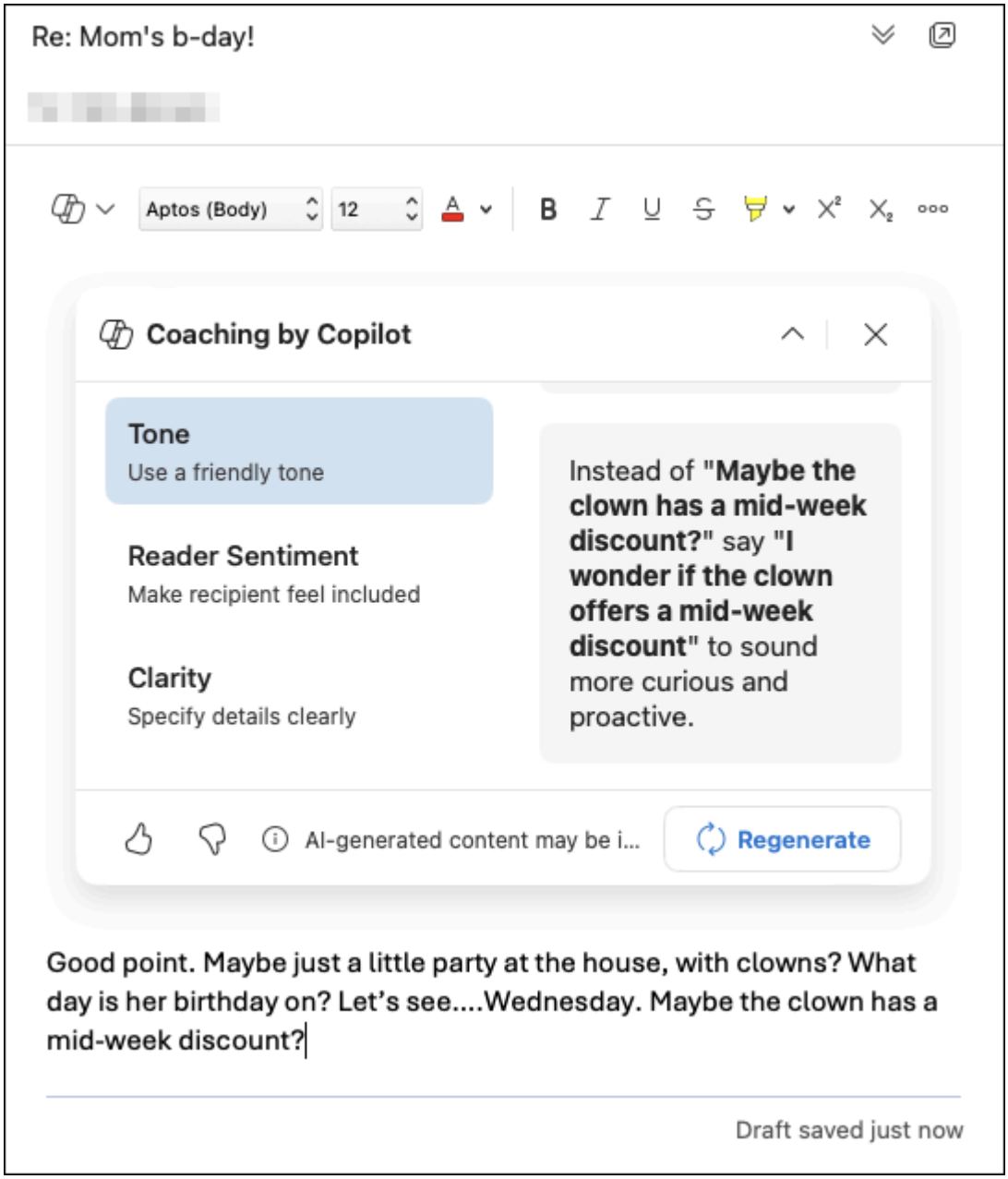


FIGURE 2-12: Copilot tells me to work on my enthusiasm.

Email coaching seems like a good feature when writing important emails to your boss or to customers. For everyday communications with friends and colleagues, it seems like following its recommendations could make your emails sound insincere and humorless.

One thing I like about Coaching by Copilot is that it leaves the decision of whether to follow any of its suggestions up to you. It doesn't even seem to have the ability to automatically insert the new text it suggests.

Meeting management

Copilot 365 in Outlook has access to your inbox and your calendar. When a meeting request comes from Microsoft Teams or another calendar app comes in via email, Outlook displays an RSVP button on the email in your list of emails. When you open the email, the details of the meeting are automatically summarized above the text of the message.

Every meeting on your calendar is available in the context menu, which you can access using the / command in Copilot Chat so you can reference your calendar while generating new emails or other documents. This is particularly helpful for coordinating with multiple people or responding to questions about your availability for (still more!) meetings.

Using GenAI for Email with Discernment

Composing new emails and responding to emails with GenAI's help generally works very well. The responses newer models generate are good in many ways. For example, they're grammatically correct, friendly, and can sometimes even be clever.

However, it's up to you to decide which circumstances AI-generated emails are appropriate for and when you should write the email yourself.

Most people would have no problem with having a GenAI model draft an email to report that the book you ordered hasn't been delivered yet and to check on the status of the order.

Asking AI to generate a love letter, a condolence letter, or a cover letter for a job application would likely seem wrong to most people. But, maybe this is just because we're all still new to this. Perhaps in the future writing your own emails will seem as archaic as sending telegrams.